

Obligatory Speaker-Oriented Rhetoricity: the Case of Cantonese *me↓*-Utterances¹

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Abstract. Rhetorical utterances employ the same sentence types as ordinary questions and assertions, yet differ systematically in how they engage with discourse structure and speaker commitment. Prevailing accounts analyze rhetoricity as Common-Ground-oriented, deriving rhetorical interpretations when the Issue raised by an utterance is already closed in the shared discourse context. This paper proposes a refinement of that view, arguing that rhetoricity is fundamentally speaker-oriented: an utterance is rhetorical when it raises a proposition that conflicts with the speaker's own public discourse commitments. I develop this proposal through a case study of Cantonese sentence-final particles, focusing on *me1* and its high-falling tonal variant *me↓*. While *me1* signals epistemic uncertainty by raising a proposition without committing the speaker to it, *me↓* obligatorily yields a rhetorical interpretation in which the speaker rejects the prejacent despite contextual evidence that might support it. I argue that *me↓* is compositionally derived from *me1* and an additional low boundary tone (L%), where *me1* suspends speaker commitment and L% introduces a requirement of incompatibility between the prejacent and the speaker's discourse commitment in the input context. Their interaction produces a stable configuration in which an Issue is raised while remaining incompatible with the speaker's commitments, thereby encoding rhetoricity in the form itself.

Keywords: sentence-final particle, rhetorical utterance, context update, discourse, Cantonese.

1. Introduction

Rhetorical utterances pose a fundamental challenge for theories of discourse: they employ the same sentence types that ordinarily perform everyday conversational work, such as asking questions or making assertions, yet they do not perform those functions in earnest (Sadock, 1971). In rhetorical utterances, the speaker's communicative intention diverges from the conventional illocutionary force associated with the form. For instance, the question uttered by B in (1) does not genuinely seek an answer, unlike a canonical information-seeking question. Similarly, in (2), although the utterance has the surface form of an assertion, the speaker's intention is not to advance a genuine claim. Rhetorical utterances thus represent a paradoxical kind of speech act: they serve as self-contained commentaries on what is already known or believed, while employing sentence types whose conventional discourse roles contradict the speaker's communicative goal.

- (1) A: Who will Amy vote for?
B: Well, who among your colleagues is her biggest supporter in the department?
(Farkas, to appear:22)

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- (2) A: I think I am going to just give up on finishing up any of my projects.
 B: Sure, and you will get your PhD degree just like that.

A central question, then, is what makes an utterance rhetorical. The prevailing view in the literature treats rhetoricality as Common-Ground-oriented (Han, 2002; Rohde, 2006; Caponigro and Sprouse, 2007; Farkas, to appear; Rohde, to appear). On this view, an utterance is interpreted as rhetorical when the Issue it raises is already settled in the shared discourse context. Rhetoricality, so understood, reflects the structure of mutual beliefs: a rhetorical question is one whose answer all interlocutors already know, and a rhetorical assertion is one whose truth value is beyond dispute. This view captures the context-dependence of rhetorical readings of otherwise unmarked sentences, where rhetoricality emerges because the Common Ground leaves no real Issue to resolve. Crucially, on this approach, rhetorical utterances and their non-rhetorical uses are formally indistinguishable; rhetorical interpretations arise only when the context supplies the relevant shared knowledge.

This paper proposes a refinement of that view. I argue that rhetoricality is best characterized not by the state of the Common Ground, but by the state of the speaker's public discourse commitments. An utterance is interpreted as rhetorical when it raises a proposition that conflicts with what the speaker is already publicly committed to. This refinement preserves the insight that rhetoricality concerns discourse structure, but locates its defining tension in the speaker's public stance rather than in mutual belief. At the same time, it allows for the possibility that certain constructions systematically force rhetorical interpretations by imposing constraints on the speaker's commitment state. In such cases, rhetoricality does not cease to be context-dependent; rather, the presence of specific morphemes triggers accommodation of a context featuring the relevant commitment conflict. This perspective both refines existing Common-Ground-based accounts and sets the stage for a reconciliation of context-dependent theories of rhetoricality with analyses on which particular constructions encode rhetoricality grammatically.

Cantonese provides a particularly revealing case study. I focus on the sentence-final particle (SFP) *me1* and its prolonged high-falling tonal variant², henceforth *me↓*. While *me1* expresses epistemic uncertainty, *me↓* conveys an unmistakably rhetorical attitude. The contrast in (3) and (4) illustrates the difference. In (3), the speaker previously assumed the proposition to be false but is now prompted by contextual evidence to reopen it for discussion. By contrast, in (4), *me↓* enforces a rhetorical interpretation: the speaker clearly rejects the proposition, even while presenting it as superficially supported by the context.

- (3) [Context: Ming has been working hard on his paper that is due very soon. His roommate Gyun sees that he is lying on the couch doing nothing. Gyun asks:]
 Nei5 leon6man2 se2-jyun4 laa3 **me1**?
 your paper write-finish LAA3 *me1*
 'You finished writing your paper?'

²Cantonese uses tone contours to distinguish lexical meanings. In Hong Kong Cantonese, for example, there are six contrastive tones (Bauer and Benedict, 1997): High Level (55, 53), Mid Rising (25), Mid-Level (33), Low Rising (23), Low Level (22), and Low Falling (21). The high-falling tone pronounced on *me↓* (51) is not one of the lexical tones. The examples in this paper are Romanized using the Linguistic Society of Hong Kong Cantonese Romanization Scheme (Jyutping), in which Tone 1 represents High Level, Tone 2 represents Mid Rising, Tone 3 represents Mid-Level, Tone 4 represents Low Falling, Tone 5 represents Low Rising, and Tone 6 represents Low Level.

- (4) [Context: Ming has been working on his paper. His friend said he should take a rest during the spring break. Ming says:]
 Leon6man2 sik1 zi6gei2 se2-jyun4 me↓
 paper know self write-finish ME↓
 ‘As if the paper could finish writing itself.’

I argue that *me↓* is compositionally derived from *me1* and an additional tonal element: a final low-tone particle (L%). Neither component alone yields rhetorical meaning; rather, rhetoricality emerges from their interaction. *Me1* contributes the absence of speaker commitment, while L% contributes a requirement of inconsistency between the prejacent and the speaker’s previous discourse commitment. When combined, these components yield a stable configuration in which the prejacent conflicts with the speaker’s own public commitments, precisely the configuration that characterizes rhetorical meaning. This composition, therefore, demonstrates what it takes for a linguistic form to encode rhetoricality rather than merely permit it. More broadly, the proposal supports a unified theory of rhetoricality that accommodates both context-dependent cases, where rhetoricality is pragmatically inferred, and conventionalized cases, where rhetoricality is grammatically encoded in the form of the utterance.

The paper is organized as follows: §2 introduces the theoretical framework, adopting the Table Model as a general framework for modeling discourse. §3 develops a speaker-oriented account of rhetoricality, arguing that rhetorical interpretations arise from conflicts between raised Issues and the speaker’s public discourse commitments. §4 resents a compositional analysis of *me↓*, deriving its obligatory rhetorical interpretation from the interaction between *me1* and a final low-tone particle L%. §5 concludes the paper.

2. Theoretical Background: The Table Model

This paper adopts the Table Model advanced by Farkas and Bruce (2010) and elaborated by Farkas and Roelofsen (2017). In this framework, the meaning of an utterance is analyzed in terms of its effects on an evolving conversational context: utterances are modeled as functions from an input context c_i to an output context c_o . A context, in turn, encodes the publicly accessible state of a discourse among a set of interlocutors A , tracking both their commitments and the open issues under discussion. The components relevant for the discussion in this paper are given in (5).

- (5) a. DISCOURSE COMMITMENTS (*DC*): for each discourse participant $a \in A$, DC_a contains propositions to which a is publicly committed.
 b. COMMON GROUND (*CG*): the set of propositions to which all discourse participants are publicly committed
 c. THE TABLE: a stack of Issues I (sets of propositions) introduced by utterances to be resolved by common-grounding one of their members (i.e., Question under Discussion, QuD)
 d. PROJECTED SET (*PS*): the set of all potential future *CG*s, containing $CG_i + p$ for each $p \in I$

The architecture of the Table Model conceptualizes conversation as a cooperative process oriented toward the expansion of the Common Ground. Discourse participants aim to increase

the set of propositions to which they are jointly and publicly committed, thereby reducing uncertainty about the shared state of the world. This process is mediated by the introduction and resolution of Issues placed on the Table. Each discourse move – whether an assertion, a question, or a bias-marked utterance – raises an Issue and proposes a space of possible updates to the Common Ground. The addressee may respond by accepting a $p \in I$ (thereby adding p to their own discourse commitments), by challenging the Issue (e.g., by introducing incompatible content), or by withholding resolution when no alternative in I is mutually acceptable. Each type of response contributes to Common Ground growth, either by adding content directly or by constraining the space of viable future Common Grounds.

Within this framework, the assertion of a sentence denoting a proposition p is typically modeled as an update function from an input context c_i to an output context c_o . The assertion places p on the Table, publicly commits the speaker to p , and projects a future Common Ground that includes p . The effect of a speaker Sp asserting p in a context c_i is schematized in (6).

$$(6) \quad \text{Assert}(p, Sp, c_i) \rightarrow c_o \text{ such that} \left[\begin{array}{lcl} T & = & T_i + \{p\} \\ DC_{Sp} & = & DC_{Sp,i} + \{p\} \\ PS & = & CG_i + \{p\} \\ c_o & = & c_i \text{ in all other respects} \end{array} \right]^{c_o}$$

To illustrate, consider a speaker asserting the sentence *linguistics is fun*. Given the analysis of assertion within the Table Model, this move achieves the contextual effects in (7). In a cooperative exchange, the addressee typically accepts the proposal, adding *linguistics is fun* to their own discourse commitments and thereby adding it to the Common Ground. Alternatively, the addressee may challenge the proposal, for instance, by asserting the incompatible proposition *linguistics is not fun*, which prevents p from being a candidate for future common grounding. The addressee may also withhold alignment with either option, leaving the Issue unresolved.

- (7) *Sp: Linguistics is fun*
- The speaker places *linguistics is fun* on the Table, sets it as the QuD
 - The speaker publicly commits to the truth of *linguistics is fun*
 - The speaker projects a future state of the Common Ground where *linguistics is fun* is jointly accepted by all interlocutors.

For a canonical polar question denoting the set of alternatives $\{p, \neg p\}$, it is likewise modeled as a function from an input context c_i to an output context c_o . In asking a polar question, the speaker Sp places the Issues $\{p, \neg p\}$ on the Table and projects future Common Grounds in which either p or $\neg p$ is added, while crucially withholding speaker commitment to either alternative. The effect of speaker Sp asking $\{p, \neg p\}$ in a context c_i is schematized in (8).

$$(8) \quad \text{Question}(\{p, \neg p\}, Sp, c_i) \rightarrow c_o \text{ such that} \left[\begin{array}{lcl} T & = & T_i + \{p, \neg p\} \\ PS & = & CG_i + \{p\}, CG_i + \{\neg p\} \\ c_o & = & c_i \text{ in all other respects} \end{array} \right]^{c_o}$$

As an illustration, consider a speaker asking the question *Is linguistics fun?*. Given the analysis of questions within the Table Model, this move achieves the contextual effects in (9). In a coop-

erative exchange, the addressee may resolve the Issue by committing to either *linguistics is fun* or to *linguistics is not fun*, thereby proposing a corresponding update to the Common Ground. The addressee may also withhold alignment altogether, leaving the Issue as unresolvable.

- (9) *Sp: Is linguistics fun?*
- a. The speaker sets *linguistics is fun* and *linguistics is not fun* as the QuD
 - b. The speaker makes no discourse commitment with regards to whether *linguistics is fun* or *linguistics is not fun*
 - c. The speaker signals that either *linguistics is fun* or *linguistics is not fun* can potentially also be committed to by all discourse participants, i.e., be added to the future Common Ground.

Farkas and Roelofsen (2017) generalize the update machinery for canonical assertions and questions by proposing a uniform utterance function, which maps an input context c_i to an output context c_o . Under this approach, each utterance denotes a set of propositions P . The speaker Sp places P on the Table, publicly commits themselves to the union of the propositions in P^3 , and projects a set of future Common Grounds in which each $p \in P$ is accepted. The effect of uttering P by a speaker Sp in a context c_i is schematized in (10), with an equivalent λ -expression in (11).

$$(10) \quad \text{UTT}(P, Sp, c_i) \rightarrow c_o \text{ such that } \left[\begin{array}{lcl} T & = & T_i + P \\ DC_{Sp} & = & DC_{Sp,i} + \bigcup P \\ PS & = & CG_i + p : p \in P \\ c_o & = & c_i \text{ in all other respects} \end{array} \right]^{c_o}$$

$$(11) \quad \text{Let } k \text{ be the type of a context.} \quad \llbracket \text{UTT} \rrbracket = \lambda P_{(st)t} . \lambda Sp_e . \lambda c_k . \left[\begin{array}{lcl} T & = & T_c + P \\ DC_{Sp} & = & DC_{Sp,c} + \bigcup P \\ PS & = & CG_c + p : p \in P \\ c' & = & c_c \text{ in all other respects} \end{array} \right]^{c'}$$

At this point, the Table Model might appear primarily suited to modeling canonical discourse moves, such as assertions and polar questions, with non-canonical phenomena like biased questions or rhetorical utterances requiring additional machinery. However, an important virtue of the framework is that the same contextual components used to model canonical moves (i.e., Issue introduction and speaker commitment) can also be used to model non-canonical discourse moves in which these components come apart. A well-studied illustration of such non-canonical behavior is provided by English rising declaratives (RDs) (Gunlogson, 2001; Malamud and Stephenson, 2015; Farkas and Roelofsen, 2017; Jeong, 2018; Rudin, 2018, 2022; Goodhue, 2025), which are syntactically declarative clauses combined with a final rising boundary tone, as exemplified in (12). Despite their declarative syntax, RDs are interpreted as raising a question, and typically give rise to bias inferences that are not present in ordinary polar interrogatives.

³For an assertion of a declarative sentence whose denotation is a singleton proposition (i.e., $P = \{p\}$) like (7), publicly committing to $\bigcup P$ is essentially committing to the singleton proposition. For a polar question whose denotation is $P = \{p, \neg p\}$ like (9), since $\bigcup P = U$, committing to $DC_{Sp,i} + \bigcup P$ is essentially not making any new commitments.

Crucially, these bias effects are not encoded as part of the conventional discourse effect of RDs. Rather, RDs are compatible with a range of bias profiles determined by discourse context: the speaker suspends commitment to the prejacent p while signaling that p is a live and contextually salient possibility (see details in Rudin, 2022).

(12) Linguistics is fun?

Despite its declarative syntax, an RD does not commit the speaker to the prejacent. Rudin (2022), among others, proposes a compositional analysis of English RDs in which a declarative sentence's ordinarily assertive update effect is modified by a rising intonation. Crucially, the rising intonation suspends the speaker's commitment to the prejacent. As a result, the utterance introduces the singleton Issue p onto the Table and projects it as a potential addition to the Common Ground, without adding p to the speaker's discourse commitments. By placing only p (and not $\neg p$) on the Table as a live Issue, the speaker signals that p is a salient possibility for discourse resolution. Any inference about speaker bias then arises from pragmatic reasoning about why the speaker has chosen to make p salient while withholding commitment to it: for example, the speaker may suspect that p is true but lack sufficient evidence to commit, or may lean toward $\neg p$ while recognizing that $\neg p$ is not a viable candidate for common grounding given the addressee is presumed to be committed to p . The direction and strength of any speaker bias are thus supplied by the discourse context rather than encoded by the form itself.

English RDs illustrate a general strategy for analyzing non-canonical discourse moves within the Table Model. Like RDs, *me*↑-marked utterances such as (3) dissociate Issue introduction from speaker commitment, motivating a parallel treatment in §4. More generally, the present analysis treats rhetoricality in the same spirit as bias in RDs: non-canonical discourse effects are derived using the same contextual components that model canonical assertions and questions, rhetorical interpretations arise from pragmatic reasoning about the discourse update rather than being hard-coded into the utterance's conventional update potential, and the relevant reasoning is defined in terms of the speaker's discourse commitments. These assumptions underpin the speaker-oriented account of rhetoricality developed in §3 and the subsequent compositional analysis of *me*↑ and *me*↓ in §4.

3. Modeling Rhetoricality

In the preceding discussion, I have used the label *rhetorical* to describe the utterances in (1) and (2), and the utterance with *me*↓ in (4) without yet specifying what rhetoricality entails.

A natural starting point is to look at rhetorical questions, the most extensively discussed class of rhetorical utterances (Sadock, 1971; Han, 2002; Rohde, 2006, to appear; Farkas, to appear). These utterances are syntactically and semantically interrogative, yet they are not open for resolution. Farkas (to appear) illustrates this with two types of rhetorical questions: *already-resolved* and *unresolvable*, as illustrated in (13) and (14).

(13) *Already-resolved rhetorical question:*

A: Who will Amy vote for?

B: Well, who among your colleagues is her biggest supporter in the department?

(Farkas, to appear:22)

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(14) *Unresolvable rhetorical question:*

A: I should give up the idea of trying to sue someone in order to recover my losses due to my Covid infection.

B: Right. After all, who passed you the virus?

(Farkas, to appear:7)

In the already-resolved case in (13), the rhetorical question is used in a context where the relevant Issue is taken to be settled. B's response is not a genuine request for information, but a rhetorical strategy for conveying that Amy will vote for whoever her biggest supporter is, an answer presumed to be mutually accessible. The rhetorical effect arises because both interlocutors are assumed to be able to recover the intended proposition, rendering the Issue effectively closed in context.

(14) exemplifies an unresolvable rhetorical question, which introduces an Issue that cannot be resolved by any rational belief state compatible with the current Common Ground. Here, B is neither seeking information about who transmitted the virus nor assuming that the answer is obvious. Rather, the rhetorical interpretation arises because no answer could coherently be added to the Common Ground, given the mutually accepted assumption that chains of transmission cannot be reliably traced. In this sense, the Issue is closed in much the same way as in already-resolved cases: it is not open for discussion, not because the answer is known, but because the question is understood to admit of no resolution that could be established given the epistemic resources assumed in the context.

On this basis, Farkas proposes that rhetorical questions are licensed when the Issue raised by the question is presupposed to be closed in the input context, as formally defined in (15). An Issue is closed in a context just in case none of its unresolved alternatives can be coherently added to the Common Ground: every proposition in the Issue that is not already accepted is incompatible with what is already mutually assumed. Unresolvable questions satisfy this condition because none of their alternatives can be consistently added to the Common Ground.⁴ Already-resolved questions also satisfy this condition: once one alternative is in the Common Ground, all competing alternatives are incompatible with it.⁵ In both cases, the question raises an Issue in a context structured such that no genuine update to the Common Ground can result.

(15) FARKAS'S CLOSURE CONDITION:

An Issue I is closed in a context c iff $\forall p \in I : p \notin CG_c, \bigcap CG_c \cap p = \emptyset$

(Adapted from Farkas, to appear:12)

Note that Farkas's proposal derives rhetoricity by evaluating whether the Issue raised by an utterance is closed relative to the Common Ground. On this view, rhetorical interpretations arise only when no alternative in the Issue can coherently be added to the set of mutually shared commitments. While this correctly captures a range of canonical rhetorical questions, I argue that tying rhetoricity to assumptions about shared belief imposes an overly strong requirement.

⁴For instance, in the unresolvable case in (14), this follows from the mutually accepted assumption that chains of transmission cannot be reliably traced: adding any proposition of the form *x passed A the virus* to the Common Ground, for any individual *x*, would contradict this background assumption.

⁵For instance, in the already-resolved case in (13), suppose it is mutually recognized that *Bob is Amy's biggest supporter in the department*, adding any other alternatives of the question (e.g., *Carla is...*, *Dani is...*) to the Common Ground would contradict this background assumption.

Consider the scenario in (16). The assertion in (16a) is interpreted as rhetorical because it is publicly recognized that the prejacent p contradicts the speaker's existing discourse commitments: Abe is committed to the belief that his art is worthless and therefore takes p to be false, even though the addressee does not share this belief. Crucially, it is not in the Common Ground that nobody would buy Abe's art, and Abe is aware that Bjork holds the opposing evaluation; nonetheless, Bjork is able to recover Abe's rhetorical intent because Abe's utterance places p on the Table while Abe's own publicly accessible commitments remain incompatible with it. A parallel reasoning applies to the question in (16b): the rhetorical effect arises because none of the alternatives denoted by the question is compatible with the speaker's commitments, independently of the addressee's beliefs.

- (16) [Context: Abe is a pessimistic artist who thinks his art is worthless. His friend, Bjork, however, thinks he makes the greatest art, thus she suggested that he sell his art at an art fair. Abe responds:]
- a. Sure, and someone will actually buy my art.
 - b. Come on, who will buy my art?

These observations motivate a refinement of existing Common Ground-based accounts. I propose that rhetoricality is fundamentally speaker-oriented: it is interpreted relative to the speaker's discourse commitments.⁶ Specifically, an utterance is interpreted as rhetorical when the speaker deliberately raises an Issue such that at least one of its members contradicts the speaker's own public discourse commitments, as defined in (17).⁷

- (17) An utterance that raises I uttered by a speaker Sp is rhetorical iff
 $\exists p \in I$ s.t. $\bigcap DC_{Sp} \cap p = \emptyset$

For an already-resolved question like (13), the utterance is interpreted as rhetorical because all alternatives denoted by the question other than the known answer are incompatible with the speaker's discourse commitments; for instance, if the speaker is publicly committed to *Bob is Amy's biggest supporter in the department*, any competing alternative (e.g. *Carla is...*, *Dani is...*) conflicts with those commitments. For an unresolvable question like (14) and (16b), the rhetorical interpretation arises because every alternative denoted by the question is incompatible with the speaker's discourse commitments, given the speaker's recognition that the question admits of no epistemically obtainable resolution. Finally, for a rhetorical assertion like (16a), rhetoricality arises because the proposition raised as the Issue directly contradicts the speaker's own publicly recognized commitments.

On this view, what rhetoricality requires is a mismatch between the Issue raised by the utterance and the speaker's commitment profile. By intentionally placing such an Issue on the Table, the speaker signals that the utterance is not meant to advance the discourse toward common

⁶The idea that discourse interpretation may be sensitive to individual speakers' public commitment states, rather than exclusively to shared Common Ground, has also been explored in other domains; see, for example, Heller and Brown-Schmidt (2023) on reference resolution and Simons (2025) on implicature generation.

⁷Note that Farkas's (to appear) Closure Condition in (15) would predict that an assertion of a proposition that has already entered the Common Ground (e.g., a speaker asserting *one plus one equals two*) would count as rhetorical. While Farkas's formalization concerns also whether a proposition in the Issue has already been accepted in the Common Ground, the current account concerns only whether a proposition in the Issue contradicts the speaker's commitments.

grounding, but rather to comment on, highlight, or exploit this commitment conflict. Rhetorical interpretations thus arise from speaker-managed inconsistency, rather than from inconsistency at the level of mutual belief.

The proposal developed here predicts that rhetoricity should be context-dependent in cases where the form itself does not encode any constraint on the speaker's commitment state: the very same sentence that receives a rhetorical interpretation in one context may fail to receive a rhetorical interpretation in another, depending on whether the Issue it raises conflicts with the speaker's discourse commitments. This prediction, however, rests on the assumption that nothing in the sentence itself forces interpretation relative to a context that yields such a conflict. I argue that Cantonese provides clear evidence that this assumption is false. In particular, Cantonese exhibits sentence types whose interpretation requires the context to involve a conflict between the content of the utterance and the speaker's commitment state. As I will show, utterances marked with the sentence-final particle *me↓* are mandatorily interpreted as rhetorical, independently of contextual variation.

4. Compositional Rhetoricity: Deriving *me↓* from *meI*

This section develops a compositional analysis of *me↓* by building on an independently motivated analysis of *meI*. Following Su (to appear), I first briefly review an account on which *meI* signals suspension of speaker commitment to the prejacent, yielding a non-assertive discourse move that nonetheless introduces a singleton Issue. I then argue that *me↓* is not a primitive rhetorical marker, but is compositionally derived from *meI* together with an additional tonal element, L%. Drawing on evidence from other sentence-final particle tonal pairs in Cantonese, I propose that L% contributes a requirement of incompatibility between the prejacent and the speaker's discourse commitments in the input context. When combined with *meI*'s commitment suspension, this tonal contribution yields a stable rhetorical interpretation: the speaker raises an Issue whose content is incompatible with their own public commitments.

As exemplified in (3), the SFP *meI* instantiates an utterance in which the speaker expresses epistemic uncertainty towards the prejacent (Wakefield, 2014; Su, to appear; see also Chor and Lam, 2023; Sybesma and Li, 2007; Matthews and Yip, 2010; Law et al., 2024; Lam, 2014; Hara, 2023). More specifically, *meI* occurs in contexts where the speaker previously believed the prejacent *p* to be false, but encounters contextual evidence supporting *p*, resulting in uncertainty about its truth and motivating the introduction of *p* as a live Issue for confirmation. This bias profile is illustrated in (18) (see Su, to appear, for detailed discussion on *meI*'s bias profile).

- (18) [Context: *Gyun thought Ming was vegan. Ming ordered chicken. Gyun asks:*]
Haa2? Nei5 sik6 juk6 ge3 me1?
huh you eat meat GE3 ME1
'Huh? You eat meat?'

Su (to appear) proposes that the SFP *meI* denotes a lexically specified utterance function. Similar to English RD discussed in §2, *p-meI* utterance places the prejacent *p* on the Table, signals that *CG_i + p* is a viable future update, and crucially, withholds any public speaker commitment to *p*. In addition, *meI* presupposes that the speaker held a $\neg p$ belief prior to encountering

some contextual evidence for p .⁸ The denotation is given (19) (see Su to appear for detailed motivation and for the connection to English RDs, following Rudin’s (2022) analysis).

$$(19) \quad \llbracket \text{ME1} \rrbracket = \lambda p_{st} . \lambda S p_e . \lambda c_k . \left[\begin{array}{lcl} T & = & T_c + \{p\} \\ PS & = & \{CG_c + p\} \\ c' & = & c_c \text{ in all other respects} \end{array} \right]^{c'}$$

defined iff $\exists t' . \exists t . \text{believe}(Sp, \neg p, t') \wedge \text{ContEvi}(p, t) : t' < t$
 where $\text{ContEvi}(p, t)$ is true iff contextual evidence for p is available at t

As illustrated in (4), when pronounced with the high-falling tone, the tonal variant $me\downarrow$ receives a rhetorical interpretation in which the speaker expresses disbelief toward the prejacent, comparable to the use of the English matrix *as if*-constructions (Rett and Starr, 2023). The rhetorical force of $me\downarrow$ is further illustrated in (20). In this context, the speaker takes it to be evident that drinking the water would not result in knowing how to fly; the absurdly high price merely creates a superficial cue suggesting otherwise.

- (20) [Context: Gyun saw a bottle of water that is sold for \$100 in the store. Gyun says:]
 Jam2-zo2 sik1 fei1 $me\downarrow$.
 drink-PERF know fly ME $\downarrow$
 ‘As if you would know how to fly after drinking it.’

The same rhetorical configuration arises in contexts where the cue supporting the prejacent is less extreme than (20), but nonetheless misleading. In the context in (21), Ming’s plan to ask Wai to proofread his paper provides a salient cue that could, on the surface, support the prejacent *Wai has free time* (p). By uttering the $p-me\downarrow$ utterance in (21a), the speaker signals that p is incompatible with their own commitments, and that its falsehood should have been evident. The rhetorical force of the utterance lies precisely in this clash between the contextual suggestion and the speaker’s stance. This contrasts with (21b): a canonical assertion of *Wai does not have free time* merely conveys the factual information, without conveying that the opposing inference was misguided or obvious. Crucially, the rhetorical interpretation of (21a) does not depend on the addressee already having any sort of established mutual beliefs or even knowing the speaker’s beliefs. The $p-me\downarrow$ utterance itself makes it clear that the speaker rejects the prejacent, even in an out-of-the-blue context, yielding a rhetorical interpretation independently of contextual assumptions about the speaker’s commitments. The $p-me\downarrow$ utterance itself makes clear that the speaker rejects the prejacent, and this interpretation is unaffected by whether the addressee also believes $\neg p$.

- (21) [Context: Ming says he wants to ask Wai to proofread his paper. Gyun says:]
 a. Keoi5 dak1 haan4 $me\downarrow$.
 he have.free.time ME $\downarrow$
 ‘As if he has free time.’

⁸I follow Goodhue’s (2023) characterization of contextual evidence as mutually available evidence in the discourse situation which, disregarding conflicting beliefs, would allow participants to infer p or at least increase the likelihood of inferring p when considered in isolation. In particular, a piece of information may count as contextual evidence for p even if p is in fact unlikely or known to be false for independent reasons. For example, if someone writes down $2 + 3 = 6$, the proposition $2 + 3 = 6$ is clearly false, but the fact that it was written down by someone nonetheless counts as contextual evidence that, in isolation, increases the likelihood of inferring $2 + 3 = 6$.

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- b. Keoi5 dou1 m4 dak1haan4.
 he even not have.free.time
 ‘He doesn’t even have any free time.’

I argue that *me↓* is decomposable into the SFP *me1* and an additional tonal component (see also Su, to appear). Previous work has documented systematic semantic contrasts across tonal variants of Cantonese SFPs, with high-tone variants correlating with tentativeness and low-tone variants with stronger, more assertive discourse effects (Matthews and Yip, 2010). A number of studies have further argued that tone itself contributes meaning in the domain of SFPs and should be treated as a minimal semantic unit (Cheung, 1986; Law, 1990; Sybesma and Li, 2007). Independent support for a compositional analysis comes from recent phonetic work showing that Cantonese low-tone SFPs arise from the combination of an inherent lexical tone and an additional low boundary tone (Lee, 2021; Lee et al., 2024), in line with the observation that the high-falling contour realized on *me↓* does not correspond to any lexical tone in Cantonese, suggesting that it is not underlyingly specified as a single tonal unit (see footnote 2). Building on these results, I propose that *me↓* is derived from the SFP *me1* and a final low-tone particle (L%), with the high-falling contour reflecting the phonetic realization of the interaction between *me1*’s high-level tone and the low boundary tone contributed by L%. The decomposition is schematized in (22).

$$(22) \quad p\text{-}me\downarrow = [[[p] me1] \%L]$$

Insight into the contribution of the tonal element in *me↓* can be gained by examining systematic contrasts across other Cantonese SFP tonal pairs. One well-documented contrast involves the the SFPs *wo3* and *wo4*. Matthews (1998) argues that the low-falling tone SFP *wo4* is derived from the mid-level tone SFP *wo3*, with the lowered tone in *wo4* associated with surprisal (see also Kwok, 1984; Luke, 1990; Law, 2004). The contrast is illustrated in (23), where *wo3* marks the preadjacent as noteworthy, while *wo4* expresses that the preadjacent is unexpected.

- (23) a. Keoi5 gam1jat6 mou5 faan1hok6 wo3.
 s/he today not.have go.to.school wo3
 ‘Notworthily, s/he didn’t go to school today.’
 b. Keoi5 gam1jat6 mou5 faan1hok6 wo4.
 s/he today not.have go.to.school wo4
 ‘Unexpectedly, s/he didn’t go to school today.’

A similar tonal contrast is observed with *tim1* and its high-falling counterpart *tim↓*. The high-level tone *tim1* is commonly assumed to be associated with additivity, whereas its high-falling tone counterpart *tim↓* is associated with mirativity (Winterstein et al., 2018). The contrast is shown in (24).

- (24) a. Keoi5 gam1jat6 mou5 faan1hok6 tim1.
 s/he today not.have go.to.school TIM1
 ‘Additionally, s/he didn’t go to school today.’
 b. Keoi5 gam1jat6 mou5 faan1hok6 tim↓.
 s/he today not.have go.to.school TIM↓
 ‘Surprisingly, s/he didn’t go to school today.’

I propose that across these tonal alternations, the final low-tone particle signals that the prejacent proposition p is incompatible with the speaker's discourse commitments in the input context, defined in (25).⁹ This generalization subsumes the contrast observed with *me1* vs. *me↓*, as well as the surprisal effects associated with *wo3* vs. *wo4* and *tim1* vs. *tim↓*.

$$(25) \quad \llbracket L\% \rrbracket = \lambda_{UTT.UTT} \text{ defined iff } \bigcap DC_{Sp,i} \cap p = \emptyset$$

The surprisal cases provide a transparent illustration of the contribution of the low or falling tonal element. In these cases, the prejacent proposition p is understood to be incompatible with the speaker's discourse commitments in the input context. Crucially, utterances marked with *wo3* and *tim1* instantiate ordinary assertions: in addition to contributing noteworthiness and additivity respectively, these particles preserve the baseline assertive effect of committing the speaker to the prejacent p . By producing *p-wo4* or *p-tim↓*, the speaker is therefore taken to have held a prior belief in $\neg p$, while nonetheless publicly committing to p in the output context. This commitment to p forces a non-monotonic update of the speaker's discourse commitments, removing the prior commitment to $\neg p$ in order to maintain logical coherence. The resulting shift from a prior commitment to $\neg p$ to a public commitment to p gives rise to the inference of surprisal or mirativity.

The contrast between *me1* and *me↓* reflects the same initial incompatibility, but differs crucially in the discourse contribution of the base particle. Unlike *wo3* and *tim1*, *me↓*'s base SFP *me1* does not commit the speaker to p in the output context; instead, it merely raises p as an Issue while suspending speaker commitment. When combined with the final low-tone particle $L\%$, the utterance continues to raise p without committing the speaker to it, despite the presence of contextual evidence for p . The persistence of commitment suspension in the face of such evidence indicates that the speaker does not take the available evidence for p to be sufficient to revise their prior belief. Given the speaker's prior belief in $\neg p$ in the input context, this configuration yields the inference that the speaker remains committed to $\neg p$. In the case of *me↓*, the rhetorical interpretation arises from the clash between introducing p as a live Issue and simultaneously signaling continued commitment to $\neg p$, a configuration that meets the condition for rhetoricality defined in (17).¹⁰ The composition is illustrated in (26).

⁹The final low-tone particle $L\%$ does not freely attach to arbitrary sentence-final material in Cantonese. Rather, it appears to require a restricted set of sentence-final particles as its host, including *wo3*, *tim1*, *me1*, and potentially *aa3* and *sin1*. In particular, $L\%$ cannot simply attach to the end of an SFP-less sentence. One possible explanation is that this restriction is related to the role of lexical tone in Cantonese: allowing a final low tone to freely attach to lexical material would risk creating tonal ambiguity or mismatch at the level of lexical identification. SFPs, which already form a distinct prosodic and morphosyntactic class, may therefore provide a privileged domain for the realization of boundary tones. I leave a systematic investigation of the licensing conditions on $L\%$ for future work.

¹⁰The notion of inconsistency in the input context contributed by the low-tone particle and the presupposition of a prior $\neg p$ belief associated with *me1* are distinct. The former is evaluated relative to the discourse transition effected by the utterance; specifically, it requires that p be incompatible with some discourse commitment in the input context. When such an incompatibility is followed by a public commitment to p in the output context (as with particles like *wo4* or *tim↓*), the inconsistency is overwritten, yielding a surprisal or mirative effect. By contrast, the presupposition of a prior $\neg p$ belief concerns the speaker's epistemic state at the time of encountering contextual evidence for p , which need not coincide with the time of utterance and does not by itself guarantee that p is incompatible with the speaker's commitments in the input context. In the present account, inconsistency in the input context is guaranteed only by the contribution of the final low-tone particle.

(26)

$$\begin{aligned}
 \llbracket p\text{-}me\downarrow \rrbracket &= \llbracket p\text{-}me1 \rrbracket \llbracket L\% \rrbracket \\
 &= \llbracket p\text{-}me1 \rrbracket \text{ defined iff } \bigcap DC_{Sp,c} \cap p = \emptyset \\
 &= \lambda Sp.\lambda c. \left[\begin{array}{ll} T &= T_c + \{p\} \\ c' &= c_c \text{ in all other respects} \end{array} \right]^{c'} \\
 &\text{defined iff } \exists t'. \exists t. \text{believe}(Sp, \neg p, t') \wedge \text{ContEvi}(p, t) : t' < t \\
 &\text{and } \bigcap DC_{Sp,c} \cap p = \emptyset
 \end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}
 \llbracket p\text{-}me1 \rrbracket &= \lambda Sp.\lambda c. \left[\begin{array}{ll} T &= T_c + \{p\} \\ PS &= \{CG_c + p\} \\ c' &= c_c \text{ in all other respects} \end{array} \right]^{c'} \\
 &\text{defined iff } \exists t'. \exists t. \text{believe}(Sp, \neg p, t') \wedge \text{ContEvi}(p, t) : t' < t
 \end{aligned}$$

An instance of this compositional contrast is illustrated in (27). In (27a), with the base SFP *me1*, the speaker has encountered some contextual evidence that superficially supports the prejacent *Wai has free time*, namely, Ming’s intention to ask Wai to proofread his paper. Prior to encountering this evidence, the speaker believed the opposite, that *Wai does not have free time*. In light of the contextual evidence, the speaker suspends commitment to whether the prejacent is true, leaving the direction and strength of their bias underspecified and dependent on contextual factors (e.g., how well Ming or Gyun knows Wai). The *p-me1* utterance therefore raises *p* as a live Issue and invites confirmation.¹¹ In (27b), the speaker encounters the same contextual evidence in superficial support of the prejacent *p* and likewise holds a prior belief in $\neg p$. Crucially, the addition of the low boundary tone in *me↓* signals that this contextual evidence has failed to alter the speaker’s commitment to $\neg p$, and the speaker still does not commit themselves to *p* in the output context. The utterance thus raises *p* as a live Issue while simultaneously signaling continued commitment to its negation. This configuration gives rise to the rhetorical implicature¹²: it should have been evident that *Wai does not have free time*, and that the contextual cue misleadingly suggests otherwise.

- (27) a. [Context: Ming says he wants to ask Wai to proofread his paper. Gyun asks:]
 Koei5 dak1haan4 me1?
 he have.free.time ME1
 ‘He has free time?’
- b. [Context: Ming says he wants to ask Wai to proofread his paper. Gyun says:]
 Koei5 dak1haan4 me↓.
 he have.free.time ME1
 ‘As if he has free time.’
- (=21a)

The case of *me↓* utterances shows that rhetoricality need not arise solely through pragmatic inference over context, but can be compositionally enforced when the grammar constrains how an utterance must be interpreted relative to context. By decomposing *me↓* into *me1* and a low boundary tone, these utterances are shown to require interpretation relative to a context in which the raised Issue conflicts with the speaker’s own discourse commitments. Importantly, this does not render rhetoricality itself non-contextual: rhetorical interpretations still arise from properties of the discourse context. Rather, *me↓* illustrates that certain morphemes can force

¹¹Note that (27a) is also compatible with rhetorical contexts where the speaker is publicly known to be committed to $\neg p$.

¹²See more on the mandatory conversational implicature generated by rhetorical utterances in Farkas (to appear).

accommodation of a context featuring the commitment conflict that gives rise to rhetoricality. In this way, *me↓* reconciles context-dependent accounts of rhetoricality with the existence of constructions that obligatorily receive rhetorical interpretations.

5. Concluding Remarks

Rhetoricality is best characterized as speaker-oriented rather than Common-Ground-oriented. An utterance is interpreted as rhetorical when it raises an Issue containing at least one proposition that is incompatible with the speaker's own public discourse commitments, yielding a mismatch between the content placed on the Table and the speaker's commitment profile. This refinement retains the central insight that rhetoricality is a discourse-structural phenomenon, while avoiding an overly strong dependence on assumptions about mutual belief. Evidence from Cantonese further shows that this configuration can be grammatically enforced: *me↓* utterances are derived compositionally from *meI* and a final low-tone particle %L, where *meI* suspends speaker commitment and L% requires incompatibility with the speaker's input commitments, together guaranteeing the commitment conflict in the output context that underwrites rhetorical interpretation. More broadly, the analysis supports a unified typology in which rhetoricality may be inferred pragmatically when forms merely permit commitment conflict, but may also be obligatory when morphemes impose the relevant discourse configuration, forcing accommodation of a context that supports rhetorical interpretation.

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